

Surinam



Area 63,039 sq miles
(163,270 sq km)
Population 500,000
Capital Paramaribo
Currency Surinamese dollar
Official language Dutch
Life expectancy 70 years



The smallest independent country in South America, Surinam is located on the north coast of the continent. Rainforested highlands take up most of the inland areas. About 90 percent of the population live along the Atlantic coast.

Brazil



Area 3,286,488 sq miles
(8,511,965 sq km)
Population 197 million
Capital Brasília
Currency Brazilian real
Official language Portuguese
Life expectancy 72 years



Brazil is the largest country in South America and the fifth-largest nation in the world. Its varied landscape includes mountains, wetlands, grasslands, deserts, and a long coastline. One-third of Brazil's land area is covered by the tropical rainforests, which grow around the massive Amazon River. Brazil's biggest and most populated cities are São Paulo and Rio de Janeiro. The iconic statue of *Cristo Redentor*, "Christ the Redeemer," overlooks the city of Rio de Janeiro and is considered one of the seven new wonders of the world. Brazil has a very diverse population and, as a result, enjoys a rich religious and cultural heritage. The seventh-largest economy in the world, Brazil is the leading producer of coffee and sugarcane ethanol, which is used as an alternative to gasoline. It also has rich reserves of gold, diamonds, oil, iron ore, and uranium.

► CARNIVAL IN RIO

Rio de Janeiro's Carnival is one of the largest festivals in the world. Celebrated 40 days before Easter, the Carnival is a massive street party with costumes, music, dance, and feasts.

Guyana



Area 83,000 sq miles
(214,970 sq km)
Population 800,000
Capital Georgetown
Currency Guyanese dollar
Official language English
Life expectancy 66 years



Guyana, on South America's northern edge, became a republic in 1966 after achieving independence from the UK. People of Indian and African origin make up about 63 percent of the population. Dense rainforests cover much of the country.



▲ HOATZIN

Guyana's national bird, the hoatzin, is also called the stinkbird because of its foul smell. Its chicks are born with claws on their wing tips.

